US Army Drone Team

Expanding the Army's Drone Team

Executive Summary

The US Army Drone Team will expand from 30 members to 60 after the 20 April - 04 May recruitment track. This expansion will facilitate Combat Training Center Rotations and Ft Rucker's Survival Evasion Resistance and Escape training. Furthermore, the US Army Drone Team will continue its effort at recruiting and motivating the next generation of Army unmanned system warfighters in collaboration with US Army Recruiting Command. Taking lessons learned from Ukraine, Iran, and other global conflicts, the US Army Drone Team will advise, innovate and integrate UAS solutions for Transformation in Contact Units across the Army.

Performance

by CPT Jacob E Bickus

The October recruitment drive sourced thirty (30) incredible UAS operators. Representing combat arms and combat support branches alike, the team consists of Soldiers with diverse educational backgrounds, unique combat and drone experience, and a persistent drive to compete and win. The Aviation Center of Excellence and 1st Aviation Brigade funded the Drone Team's attendance at three separate US National Drone Association Competitions, the US Army's Best Drone Warfighter Competition, the Military International Drone Racing Tournament in the United Kingdom, the Phase I Drone Dominance Gauntlet at Ft Benning, and various other military conferences across the US. USAREC funded the Drone Team to attend several recruitment drives across the country including MEGACON in Orlando, Daytona 500, Grand Prix in California, Future Farmers of America in Atlanta, Washington Commanders Activation in DC, and many others.

We have brought in Soldiers from as far as Korea to compete in an event in Florida. But time after time the TDY funds have proven worth it. SGT Koehn a member of 4th ID on rotation to South Korea was instrumental in our team's performance during the official USNDA competition in December and our force on force night operation against the Navy Seals. SGT Koehn operated the ISR drone that spotted the Navy Seal hiding in the woods during their attempted drone assault on our building compound. His report allowed SGT Brower from Joint Base Lewis McCord strike the Navy Seal position with a one way attack FPV drone. Both Soldiers were able to take the lessons learned from the competition back to their respective units and provide valuable UAS training.

In February, the US Army Drone Team evaluated over a dozen FPV drones during the Drone Dominance Gauntlet at Ft Benning. Immediately following the event we published our feedback to inform Commanders which systems were worth purchasing and which systems needed additional development.

Through our bailment access to industries newest designs, combined with our state of the art 3D printing lab, and through collaboration with the Unmanned Advance Lethality Course the US Army Drone Team is spearheading innovation. SFC Ringsmuth from Ft Huachuca recently designed a cheap helmet mounted visor set that allows FPV operators to maintain situational awareness while operating day and night.

Potential

The US Army Drone Team demonstrated in Q1FY26 that we would compete and win. In Q2, we applied our lessons from competition to innovate new equipment and codified internal team tactics. In Q3, we will expand the team to support training.



Figure 1: *US National Drone Association presents awards to US Army Drone Team at the Full Sail University December 2025. The team boasted the fastest individual lap time and the overall race champion.*

The most realistic training the Army offers can be found at the Combat Training Centers. The US Army Drone Team will embody "leaders to the point of friction" by beginning regular rotations in support of Transformation in Contact units "in the box." Supporting Commanders as advisors and trainers while exposing UAS tactics to realistic and harsh conditions, the US Army Drone Team aims to increase lethality and survivability in a contested UAS environment.



Figure 2: *The US Army Drone Team NCOIC, SSG Smith, demonstrating the VelociDrone FPV simulator to COL Merkel.*